PERSONALITY TYPES

A Comprehensive Guide to the Major Models of Human Personality

Big Five • Myers-Briggs • Enneagram • Type A/B • DISC • Temperaments

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About this document. This guide surveys the most widely used frameworks for describing differences in human personality. Some, such as the Big Five, are grounded in decades of empirical research; others, such as the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator and the Enneagram, are popular tools for self-reflection and team building whose scientific standing is more limited.

1. Introduction: What Is Personality?

Personality refers to the relatively stable patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving that distinguish one person from another. When we describe a friend as outgoing, a colleague as meticulous, or a sibling as anxious, we are making judgments about personality. These patterns tend to remain consistent across situations and over time, although they are never perfectly fixed. A shy person may become lively among close friends, and most people become somewhat more conscientious and emotionally stable as they age.

Psychologists distinguish between **traits** and **types**. A trait is a dimension on which everyone can be placed, like height: most people fall near the middle, and few lie at the extremes. A type, by contrast, is a category: a person either belongs to it or does not. Trait models such as the Big Five describe people with scores along continuous scales. Type models such as the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator sort people into discrete groups with memorable labels. Types are easier to remember and discuss, while traits generally provide more precise and reliable measurement.

Where does personality come from? Twin and adoption studies suggest that roughly 40 to 60 percent of the variation in personality traits between people is attributable to genetic differences. The rest arises from environmental influences, especially experiences unique to each individual rather than those shared by siblings growing up in the same household. Culture, life events, relationships, and work roles all shape how underlying tendencies are expressed.

Personality matters because it predicts important life outcomes. Research has linked personality traits to academic achievement, job performance, relationship satisfaction, physical health, and even longevity. Understanding personality can help individuals choose suitable careers, communicate more effectively, and develop greater self-awareness. It can also help organizations build balanced teams and design better working environments.

This guide introduces the main frameworks used to describe personality, from ancient theories of temperament to modern statistical models. Along the way, it highlights both the insights these models offer and the cautions needed when applying them to real people, who are always more complex than any label.

2. A Brief History of Personality Typing

The Four Temperaments

The earliest known personality typology comes from ancient Greece. The physician Hippocrates (c. 460-370 BCE) proposed that health depended on the balance of four bodily fluids, or humors. Several centuries later the Roman physician Galen linked each humor to a temperament. Although the biology was wrong, the four temperaments shaped Western thinking about character for nearly two thousand years and still echo in modern models.

Temperament	Humor	Traditional description
Sanguine	Blood	Cheerful, sociable, optimistic, talkative, and pleasure-seeking.
Choleric	Yellow bile	Ambitious, decisive, energetic, dominant, and quick to anger.
Melancholic	Black bile	Thoughtful, analytical, detail-oriented, reserved, and prone to sadness.
Phlegmatic	Phlegm	Calm, relaxed, peaceful, reliable, and sometimes passive.

Jung and Psychological Types

In 1921 the Swiss psychiatrist Carl Gustav Jung published *Psychological Types*. Jung proposed that people differ in their general attitude, being either **extraverted** (oriented toward the outer world of people and objects) or **introverted** (oriented toward the inner world of thoughts and feelings). He also described four psychological functions: thinking, feeling, sensation, and intuition. Jung's ideas became the foundation of the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator.

Eysenck and the Rise of Trait Psychology

In the mid-twentieth century, psychologists began using statistical methods, especially factor analysis, to find the basic dimensions of personality. Hans Eysenck proposed three broad dimensions: extraversion, neuroticism, and psychoticism. Raymond Cattell identified sixteen personality factors. Building on the *lexical hypothesis*, the idea that important personality differences become encoded in everyday language, researchers such as Lewis Goldberg, Paul Costa, and Robert McCrae eventually converged on five broad factors, now known as the Big Five.

3. The Big Five (OCEAN) Model

The Big Five, also called the Five-Factor Model, is the most widely accepted framework in academic personality psychology. It describes personality using five broad dimensions, often remembered with the acronym **OCEAN**. Each person receives a score on each dimension, and scores are usually distributed in a bell curve. The model has been replicated across dozens of languages and cultures, and its traits are measured with instruments such as the NEO Personality Inventory (NEO-PI-R) and the Big Five Inventory (BFI).

Trait	High scorers tend to be	Low scorers tend to be
Openness to Experience	Curious, imaginative, artistic, open to new ideas and unconventional values.	Practical, conventional, prefer routine and familiar experiences.
Conscientiousness	Organized, dependable, disciplined, goal-directed, careful.	Spontaneous, flexible, sometimes careless or disorganized.
Extraversion	Outgoing, energetic, talkative, assertive, seek social stimulation.	Reserved, quiet, independent, prefer solitude or small groups.
Agreeableness	Warm, cooperative, trusting, compassionate, eager to help.	Competitive, skeptical, direct, challenging, sometimes critical.
Neuroticism	Prone to anxiety, worry, moodiness, and stress reactivity.	Calm, emotionally stable, resilient under pressure.

Facets

Each of the five broad traits contains narrower facets. In the NEO-PI-R, for example, extraversion includes warmth, gregariousness, assertiveness, activity, excitement-seeking, and positive emotions. Two people with the same extraversion score might differ considerably at the facet level: one may be highly assertive but not especially gregarious, while the other loves crowds but avoids taking charge.

What the Big Five Predicts

Conscientiousness is the most consistent personality predictor of job performance and academic success across occupations. Neuroticism predicts vulnerability to depression and anxiety disorders. Extraversion is associated with leadership emergence and positive mood, agreeableness with relationship quality and cooperative behavior, and openness with creativity, intellectual interests, and liberal political attitudes. Some researchers have proposed a sixth factor, Honesty-Humility, which forms the HEXACO model and captures sincerity, fairness, and modesty.

4. The Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI)

The Myers-Briggs Type Indicator was developed during the 1940s by Katharine Cook Briggs and her daughter Isabel Briggs Myers. Inspired by Jung's *Psychological Types*, they wanted to create a practical tool that would help people understand themselves and find work suited to their preferences. Today the MBTI is one of the most widely used personality assessments in the world, taken by millions of people each year in schools, businesses, and counseling settings.

The MBTI sorts people according to four pairs of opposite preferences. Combining one letter from each pair produces a four-letter code, giving sixteen possible types.

Dimension	Preference A	Preference B
Energy Where do you focus attention?	**Extraversion (E)**: energized by people, action, and the outer world.	**Introversion (I)**: energized by reflection, ideas, and time alone.
Information How do you take in information?	**Sensing (S)**: trusts concrete facts, details, and present realities.	**Intuition (N)**: looks for patterns, meanings, and future possibilities.
Decisions How do you make choices?	**Thinking (T)**: prioritizes logic, consistency, and objective criteria.	**Feeling (F)**: prioritizes values, harmony, and effects on people.
Lifestyle How do you approach the outer world?	**Judging (J)**: prefers structure, plans, and closure.	**Perceiving (P)**: prefers flexibility, spontaneity, and open options.

Cognitive Functions

Beneath the four letters, MBTI theory describes eight cognitive functions: extraverted and introverted versions of thinking, feeling, sensing, and intuition. Each type is said to have a dominant function, a supporting auxiliary function, and less developed tertiary and inferior functions. For instance, an INTJ is described as leading with introverted intuition (Ni), supported by extraverted thinking (Te).

Temperament Groups

The sixteen types are often grouped into four families of four. A popular scheme, used in the following chapters, groups them as **Analysts** (NT), **Diplomats** (NF), **Sentinels** (SJ), and **Explorers** (SP). This grouping is similar to David Keirsey's temperaments of Rationals, Idealists, Guardians, and Artisans.

5. The 16 Types: Analysts (NT)

Analysts combine intuition with thinking. They are drawn to ideas, systems, and theories, and they value competence, logic, and independence. They enjoy solving complex problems and often question established rules.

INTJ — The Architect

INTJs are strategic, independent thinkers who build long-range plans and pursue them with determination. They see how pieces of a system fit together and constantly look for ways to improve it.

Strengths: vision, self-confidence, high standards, decisiveness. **Challenges:** can seem aloof, impatient with inefficiency, dismissive of emotions. **Typical careers:** scientist, systems engineer, strategist, architect.

INTP — The Logician

INTPs are curious, analytical, and endlessly inventive. They love exploring theories and abstract puzzles, often more for the joy of understanding than for practical results.

Strengths: originality, objectivity, intellectual depth. **Challenges:** procrastination, absent-mindedness, difficulty with routine. **Typical careers:** researcher, programmer, philosopher, mathematician.

ENTJ — The Commander

ENTJs are bold, energetic leaders who organize people and resources to achieve ambitious goals. They think strategically and act decisively.

Strengths: leadership, efficiency, confidence, long-term planning. **Challenges:** can be domineering, blunt, or intolerant of mistakes. **Typical careers:** executive, entrepreneur, lawyer, management consultant.

ENTP — The Debater

ENTPs are quick-witted, inventive, and love intellectual challenge. They enjoy arguing both sides of an issue and generating unconventional ideas.

Strengths: creativity, adaptability, charisma, enthusiasm. **Challenges:** may neglect follow-through, argue for sport, or get bored easily. **Typical careers:** inventor, marketer, journalist, startup founder.

6. The 16 Types: Diplomats (NF)

Diplomats combine intuition with feeling. They are guided by values and ideals, care deeply about personal growth and meaningful relationships, and often seek to help others reach their potential.

INFJ — The Advocate

INFJs are insightful, principled idealists who seek meaning and connection. Quiet yet determined, they often work behind the scenes for causes they believe in.

Strengths: empathy, insight, integrity, long-term vision. **Challenges:** perfectionism, burnout, reluctance to open up. **Typical careers:** counselor, psychologist, writer, nonprofit leader.

INFP — The Mediator

INFPs are gentle, imaginative, and driven by strong inner values. They seek authenticity and harmony and are often drawn to creative expression.

Strengths: compassion, creativity, open-mindedness, idealism. **Challenges:** self-criticism, impracticality, sensitivity to conflict. **Typical careers:** author, artist, social worker, therapist.

ENFJ — The Protagonist

ENFJs are warm, charismatic leaders who inspire and mobilize others. They are attuned to people's needs and enjoy helping groups work together.

Strengths: persuasiveness, empathy, reliability, organization. **Challenges:** may overcommit, neglect their own needs, or seek approval. **Typical careers:** teacher, HR manager, coach, politician.

ENFP — The Campaigner

ENFPs are enthusiastic, creative, and sociable free spirits who see life as full of possibilities. They connect easily with people and ideas.

Strengths: energy, curiosity, communication, optimism. **Challenges:** disorganization, difficulty focusing, emotional ups and downs. **Typical careers:** journalist, entrepreneur, actor, public relations specialist.

7. The 16 Types: Sentinels (SJ)

Sentinels combine sensing with judging. They are practical, dependable, and value order, tradition, and security. Many communities and organizations rely on them to keep things running smoothly.

ISTJ — The Logistician

ISTJs are responsible, thorough, and fact-minded. They honor commitments, follow procedures, and take pride in doing a job correctly.

Strengths: reliability, honesty, attention to detail. **Challenges:** rigidity, resistance to change, reluctance to express feelings. **Typical careers:** accountant, auditor, police officer, project manager.

ISFJ — The Defender

ISFJs are warm, conscientious protectors who quietly care for the people around them. They remember details about others and show love through practical help.

Strengths: loyalty, patience, supportiveness, diligence. **Challenges:** difficulty saying no, overwork, avoidance of conflict. **Typical careers:** nurse, teacher, librarian, administrator.

ESTJ — The Executive

ESTJs are organized, decisive administrators who value rules, order, and clear expectations. They enjoy taking charge and getting results.

Strengths: leadership, dedication, directness, efficiency. **Challenges:** inflexibility, impatience, can seem judgmental. **Typical careers:** manager, military officer, judge, operations director.

ESFJ — The Consul

ESFJs are caring, sociable, and community-minded. They enjoy creating harmony, organizing events, and making sure everyone feels included.

Strengths: warmth, loyalty, practicality, cooperation. **Challenges:** need for approval, sensitivity to criticism, worry about status. **Typical careers:** healthcare worker, event planner, sales, teacher.

8. The 16 Types: Explorers (SP)

Explorers combine sensing with perceiving. They live in the moment, respond quickly to their surroundings, and value freedom, action, and hands-on experience.

ISTP — The Virtuoso

ISTPs are cool-headed, practical problem-solvers who love understanding how things work. They are skilled with tools and stay calm in a crisis.

Strengths: resourcefulness, independence, technical skill. **Challenges:** risk-taking, privacy to the point of distance, low patience for theory. **Typical careers:** mechanic, pilot, engineer, forensic scientist.

ISFP — The Adventurer

ISFPs are gentle, sensitive artists who express themselves through action and aesthetics rather than words. They value personal freedom and beauty.

Strengths: creativity, kindness, adaptability, sensitivity. **Challenges:** unpredictability, dislike of planning, avoidance of conflict. **Typical careers:** designer, musician, chef, veterinarian.

ESTP — The Entrepreneur

ESTPs are energetic, perceptive, and action-oriented. They thrive on excitement and are quick to seize opportunities.

Strengths: boldness, practicality, sociability, quick thinking. **Challenges:** impulsiveness, impatience, disregard for rules. **Typical careers:** salesperson, paramedic, athlete, entrepreneur.

ESFP — The Entertainer

ESFPs are spontaneous, fun-loving, and generous. They enjoy being around people, bring energy to any gathering, and live fully in the present.

Strengths: enthusiasm, warmth, observation, practicality. **Challenges:** difficulty with long-term planning, distractibility. **Typical careers:** performer, tour guide, event host, flight attendant.

9. The Enneagram

The Enneagram describes nine personality types arranged around a nine-pointed geometric figure. Its modern form was developed in the twentieth century by Oscar Ichazo and Claudio Naranjo, drawing on a mixture of older spiritual and philosophical traditions. Unlike trait models, the Enneagram focuses on core motivations: each type is defined by a basic fear and a basic desire that drive behavior, often outside conscious awareness.

Type	Name	Core desire	Core fear
1	The Reformer	To be good, ethical, and correct	Being corrupt or defective
2	The Helper	To be loved and needed	Being unwanted or unloved
3	The Achiever	To be valuable and successful	Being worthless
4	The Individualist	To be unique and authentic	Having no identity or significance
5	The Investigator	To be competent and capable	Being helpless or incapable
6	The Loyalist	To have security and support	Being without guidance or support
7	The Enthusiast	To be satisfied and free	Being deprived or trapped in pain
8	The Challenger	To protect self and control destiny	Being harmed or controlled
9	The Peacemaker	To have inner and outer peace	Loss, separation, and conflict

Triads, Wings and Arrows

The nine types are grouped into three centers of intelligence. Types 8, 9, and 1 form the **body** or instinctive center, concerned with autonomy and anger. Types 2, 3, and 4 form the **heart** or feeling center, concerned with identity and shame. Types 5, 6, and 7 form the **head** or thinking center, concerned with security and fear.

Most people are said to be influenced by one of the two types adjacent to their own on the circle, called a **wing**. A Type 4 with a strong 5 wing (written 4w5) may be more introspective and intellectual, while a 4w3 may be more expressive and image-conscious. Lines connecting the points indicate directions of **integration** (growth) and **disintegration** (stress). Under stress, for example, a Type 9 may take on the anxious qualities of a Type 6, while in growth they may adopt the decisiveness of a Type 3.

The Enneagram is widely used in coaching, spiritual direction, and personal development. Its strength lies in prompting reflection on motivation rather than surface behavior. However, empirical research on its validity is limited, and results depend heavily on honest self-reflection.

10. Type A, B, C and D Personalities

The Type A and Type B distinction began not in psychology but in cardiology. In the 1950s, cardiologists Meyer Friedman and Ray Rosenman noticed that many of their heart patients shared a distinctive behavior pattern: they were competitive, impatient, and constantly in a hurry. They called this pattern **Type A behavior** and its opposite **Type B**. Later researchers proposed Types C and D.

Type	Key characteristics	Associated outcomes
Type A	Competitive, ambitious, time-urgent, impatient, hostile when frustrated, multitasking.	High achievement; hostility component linked to cardiovascular risk and stress.
Type B	Relaxed, patient, easygoing, reflective, less driven by deadlines.	Lower stress; may be more creative and better at enjoying leisure.
Type C	Cooperative, appeasing, suppresses negative emotions, avoids conflict.	Once speculatively linked to illness; evidence is weak and contested.
Type D	'Distressed': high negative emotion combined with social inhibition.	Associated in some studies with poorer heart-disease outcomes and depression.

What Later Research Found

Early studies suggested that Type A people had roughly twice the risk of coronary heart disease. Later, more careful studies produced mixed results. Researchers eventually concluded that the overall Type A pattern was less important than one specific component: **hostility**, especially cynical mistrust and anger. Ambition and drive themselves appear to be largely harmless or even beneficial.

Type D personality, introduced by Johan Denollet in the 1990s, combines negative affectivity (a tendency to experience worry, gloom, and irritation) with social inhibition (a tendency not to share those emotions with others). Research on Type D continues, with some studies finding links to poorer health outcomes and others finding smaller effects once other risk factors are controlled.

Today, the Type A/B labels are used more in everyday conversation than in scientific research, where they have largely been absorbed into trait models. Type A resembles a combination of high conscientiousness, low agreeableness, and elevated neuroticism, while Type D closely resembles high neuroticism combined with introversion.

11. The DISC Model

The DISC model is based on the work of psychologist William Moulton Marston, who described four primary emotional and behavioral styles in his 1928 book *Emotions of Normal People*. Marston (who also created the comic book character Wonder Woman) did not develop an assessment himself; later industrial psychologists built DISC questionnaires from his ideas. Today DISC is widely used in workplaces, especially in sales, management training, and team development.

DISC places people along two axes: whether they are more **outgoing or reserved**, and whether they are more **task-oriented or people-oriented**. The combination produces four styles.

Style	Focus	Typical behavior	Communication tips
D — Dominance	Outgoing, task-oriented	Direct, results-driven, decisive, competitive, enjoys challenges.	Be brief, focus on outcomes, avoid excessive detail.
I — Influence	Outgoing, people-oriented	Enthusiastic, persuasive, optimistic, sociable, expressive.	Be friendly, allow time to talk, share ideas and recognition.
S — Steadiness	Reserved, people-oriented	Patient, loyal, calm, supportive, dislikes sudden change.	Be sincere, provide reassurance, explain changes gradually.
C — Conscientiousness	Reserved, task-oriented	Analytical, precise, systematic, quality-focused, cautious.	Provide data and details, be accurate, allow time to think.

Most people show a blend of styles, with one or two dominant. A person with a high D and high C profile, for instance, might be both decisive and detail-oriented, while an I-S blend might be warm, encouraging, and steady. DISC emphasizes observable behavior and communication preferences rather than deep motivations, which makes it practical for improving teamwork.

Like the MBTI, DISC is primarily a commercial and developmental tool. Its descriptions map loosely onto the Big Five: Dominance and Influence relate to extraversion, Steadiness to agreeableness and low neuroticism, and Conscientiousness to the Big Five trait of the same name. It is not recommended for hiring decisions, because evidence linking DISC styles to job performance is limited.

12. Scientific Evaluation and Criticism

Personality assessments are judged primarily by two criteria. **Reliability** asks whether a test gives consistent results, for example when the same person takes it twice a few weeks apart. **Validity** asks whether the test measures what it claims to measure and predicts meaningful outcomes. Frameworks differ greatly on these criteria.

Strengths of the Big Five

The Big Five has strong support. Its five factors emerge repeatedly in studies across cultures, show substantial test-retest reliability, are partly heritable, and predict real-world outcomes such as job performance, health, and relationship stability. For these reasons, it is the standard model in academic research.

Criticisms of the MBTI

The MBTI is popular but has faced substantial criticism. First, it forces continuous traits into either-or categories. Most people score near the middle of each dimension, so a small change in answers can flip a letter. Studies have found that a considerable proportion of people receive a different type when retested after only a few weeks. Second, research does not support the theory of cognitive function stacks. Third, the MBTI omits anything resembling neuroticism, one of the most important dimensions of personality. Nevertheless, its four scales do correlate with four of the Big Five traits, and many users find it a useful vocabulary for discussing differences.

The Barnum Effect

A major risk with any personality description is the **Barnum effect**, also called the Forer effect: the tendency to accept vague, generally flattering statements as accurate descriptions of oneself. In a classic 1948 experiment, Bertram Forer gave students a supposedly personalized profile that was actually identical for everyone; on average they rated it as highly accurate. Type descriptions that are broad and positive can feel insightful even when they would fit almost anyone.

Other Cautions

Labels can become self-fulfilling or limiting if people believe their type fixes what they can do. Personality also interacts with situations: behavior depends on context as well as disposition. Finally, many online tests are unvalidated and should be treated as entertainment rather than science.

13. Applications of Personality Typing

Self-Awareness and Personal Growth

For many people, the greatest value of personality frameworks is reflection. Learning that one prefers introversion, for instance, can help a person understand why large social events feel draining and plan recovery time. Recognizing a tendency toward perfectionism or conflict avoidance is often the first step toward changing it.

Careers and Education

Career counselors use personality and interest inventories to help students and job seekers explore fields that suit their preferences. Teachers can use knowledge of personality differences to vary teaching methods, offering both group discussion for extraverted learners and independent work for introverted ones.

Teams and Leadership

Organizations use tools like the MBTI and DISC in team-building workshops to improve communication and reduce conflict. A team that understands that some members want quick decisions while others need time to analyze can design meetings that serve both. Leadership development programs use Big Five based assessments to help managers understand their strengths and blind spots.

Hiring and Selection

Validated Big Five measures, particularly of conscientiousness, are used alongside other methods in employee selection. Ethical guidelines warn against using type-based tools such as the MBTI for hiring, because they were not designed for that purpose and their predictive validity is weak.

Relationships and Health

Personality research informs couples counseling and clinical psychology. Agreeableness and emotional stability predict relationship satisfaction, while high neuroticism is a risk factor for anxiety and depression. Understanding these links helps clinicians tailor treatment and helps individuals build healthier habits and relationships.

Marketing and Technology

Companies increasingly use personality insights to personalize advertising and recommendations. Studies have shown that digital footprints, such as social media likes, can predict Big Five traits with surprising accuracy. This raises important ethical questions about privacy, consent, and manipulation.

14. Conclusion and Further Reading

Humans have tried to categorize personality for thousands of years, from the four humors of ancient Greece to modern statistical models. Each framework offers a different lens. The Big Five provides the most scientifically robust description of how people differ. The MBTI offers an accessible vocabulary for discussing preferences. The Enneagram invites reflection on underlying motivations. Type A and Type D research highlights links between personality and health, and DISC gives practical guidance for workplace communication.

The wisest approach is to use these models as tools for understanding rather than boxes that define people. Every person is a unique combination of traits shaped by genes, experiences, culture, and choices. Personality is relatively stable, but it is not destiny: people grow, adapt, and change throughout their lives. Used thoughtfully, personality frameworks can foster empathy, improve communication, and support personal growth.

Key Takeaways

- Traits describe continuous dimensions; types sort people into categories.
- The Big Five (OCEAN) is the best-supported scientific model of personality.
- The MBTI yields 16 types from four preference pairs, but its reliability is limited.
- The Enneagram focuses on nine core motivations, fears, and desires.
- Hostility, not ambition, is the harmful component of Type A behavior.
- DISC describes four behavioral styles useful for workplace communication.
- Beware of the Barnum effect and avoid using type tools for high-stakes decisions.

Further Reading

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